ELEPHANT FOOT

Website Build Checklist

From project intake to launch and handoff. Tailored to the $299 package; additional work follows the signed project scope.

Project: _____
Client: _____
Domain: _____
Target launch date: _____

1. Before you start

- ☐ Review the client inquiry form.
- ☐ Confirm the website purpose and target audience.
- ☐ Choose the main visitor action: call, inquire, book, or view work.
- ☐ Agree on the page list: up to five pages for the standard package.
- ☐ Confirm included features and separately quoted extras.
- ☐ Agree on revision rounds, payment timing, and launch responsibilities.
- ☐ Confirm who pays for domain, hosting, and third-party tools.
- ☐ Get the service agreement signed.
- ☐ Confirm the timeline after receiving required content and access.

2. Collect content and assets

- ☐ Business name, description, services, and contact information.
- ☐ Final text for each page.
- ☐ Logo and preferred colors.
- ☐ Approved photos and graphics.
- ☐ Social media links.
- ☐ Business hours, location, and service area, if relevant.
- ☐ Approved testimonials and credentials, if used.
- ☐ Contact-form destination email.
- ☐ Existing booking links, if included.
- ☐ Domain and hosting access through appropriate account invitations.
- ☐ Client confirmation that supplied materials can be used.
- ☐ Client-supplied privacy or other policy text needed for the agreed site.

3. Set up the project

- ☐ Create the project repository.

- [ ] Set up the framework, dependencies, and folder structure.
- [ ] Create a preview deployment.
- [ ] Configure environment variables.
- [ ] Keep secrets and private credentials out of the repository and browser code.
- [ ] Create a central content/config file where practical.
- [ ] Set up shared header, footer, buttons, and page layouts.
- [ ] Verify the project builds successfully.

4. Design and build

- [ ] Establish fonts, colors, spacing, and button styles.
- [ ] Build the agreed pages.
- [ ] Make the business offer clear near the top of the homepage.
- [ ] Add a clear primary call to action.
- [ ] Build desktop and mobile navigation.
- [ ] Keep layouts and components consistent.
- [ ] Add approved images and content.
- [ ] Check image cropping on different screen sizes.
- [ ] Remove placeholder text, fake testimonials, and unused sections.
- [ ] Use animation only where it supports the experience.

5. Responsive and accessibility checks

- [ ] Test narrow phones, wider phones, tablets, and desktops.

These are first checks, not proof of complete accessibility compliance.

- [ ] Check for unintended horizontal scrolling.
- [ ] Ensure headings, buttons, and images do not overlap.
- [ ] Test portrait and landscape layouts.
- [ ] Check that navigation works without a mouse.
- [ ] Make keyboard focus visible.
- [ ] Give form fields visible, correctly associated labels.
- [ ] Clearly identify required fields and explain validation errors.
- [ ] Add meaningful alternative text to informative images.
- [ ] Mark decorative images appropriately.
- [ ] Check text/background contrast.
- [ ] Zoom in and check that content remains readable and usable.
- [ ] Respect reduced-motion preferences.

6. Contact form and interactions

- [ ] Connect the form to the agreed client inbox.
- [ ] Validate required fields and email addresses.
- [ ] Show a clear submitting state.
- [ ] Prevent accidental duplicate submissions.
- [ ] Show a success message only after a successful submission.
- [ ] Show a useful error message if submission fails.
- [ ] Add appropriate spam protection.
- [ ] Submit a real test and confirm receipt with the client.
- [ ] Check that replies can reach the person who submitted the form.
- [ ] Test phone, email, social, and booking links.
- [ ] Test menus, accordions, galleries, and other included interactions.

7. SEO basics and analytics

- [ ] Add a unique, descriptive title to each page.

A sitemap and SEO setup do not guarantee indexing or rankings.

- [ ] Write an appropriate meta description for each page.
- [ ] Use clear headings and descriptive links.
- [ ] Confirm business name and contact details are accurate.
- [ ] Set canonical URLs to the final domain where appropriate.
- [ ] Generate a sitemap using production URLs.
- [ ] Check that production pages are not accidentally marked noindex.
- [ ] Check crawl settings for unintended blocking.
- [ ] Add a favicon and social-sharing metadata.
- [ ] Configure the agreed analytics tool.
- [ ] Verify analytics records a test visit.
- [ ] Confirm analytics settings and related disclosures with the client.
- [ ] Set up Search Console if included in the agreed scope.

8. Performance and quality testing

- [ ] Resize and compress oversized images.
- [ ] Avoid loading unnecessary scripts, fonts, and libraries.
- [ ] Check for broken images and missing assets.
- [ ] Check the browser console for unexpected errors.
- [ ] Test loading on a slower connection.
- [ ] Run Lighthouse or another automated audit.

- [ ] Manually test the site too; do not rely only on audit scores.
- [ ] Test Chrome, Safari, Firefox, and Edge where available.
- [ ] Test at least one real phone.
- [ ] Check every internal and external link.
- [ ] Test a nonexistent URL and the 404 page.
- [ ] For client-side routing, reload each page directly to check deployment routing.
- [ ] Proofread every page.

9. Client review and approval

- [ ] Send the completed preview link.
- [ ] Explain what feedback is needed and how to submit it.
- [ ] Collect feedback in one consolidated list.
- [ ] Complete included revisions.
- [ ] Correct anything that does not match the agreed scope.
- [ ] Confirm approval of content, design, and functionality in writing.
- [ ] Send the invoice after the build, following signed payment terms.
- [ ] Confirm payment before launch if that is the agreed arrangement.

10. Launch

- [ ] Confirm the correct production project and domain.
- [ ] Configure domain records.
- [ ] Verify HTTPS works.
- [ ] Confirm the preferred domain and redirects.
- [ ] Set production environment variables.
- [ ] Deploy the approved version.
- [ ] Open every page on the live domain.
- [ ] Retest the contact form on the live site.
- [ ] Recheck booking, phone, email, and navigation links.
- [ ] Verify sitemap, analytics, and social-sharing information.
- [ ] Check that preview URLs or development settings were not carried into production.

11. Handoff and follow-up

- [ ] Deliver the source code as agreed.
- [ ] Provide setup and editing instructions.
- [ ] Confirm ownership and access for domain, hosting, and analytics accounts.
- [ ] Record third-party costs and renewal responsibilities.

- [ ] Explain what ongoing maintenance is and is not included.
- [ ] Explain the agreed defect-correction/support period.
- [ ] Remove unnecessary access and rotate temporary credentials.
- [ ] Keep a copy of the approved release.
- [ ] Confirm the client received the handoff materials.
- [ ] Ask permission before displaying the site in your portfolio.

Final launch gate

- [ ] Every agreed page is finished.
- [ ] The mobile experience works.
- [ ] The contact form reaches the client inbox.
- [ ] No critical links or interactions are broken.
- [ ] SEO basics, sitemap, and analytics are configured.
- [ ] The client has approved the site.
- [ ] Payment and launch follow the signed agreement.
- [ ] The live domain works over HTTPS.
- [ ] Source code and account access have been handed over.